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Eternal Life in Eternal Love

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Eternal Life in Eternal Love

Day 14

This is eternal life, that they may know You, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom You have sent. (John 17:3)

Eternal life is not just going to heaven when you die. It is not a one-time gift God gives to you and then He walks away. Eternal life is not a destination to be reached; it is a relationship to be enjoyed. Eternal life is you sharing yourself with God and God sharing Himself with you. It is living as part of the Trinity's mutual love and goodness. Eternal life is knowing God.

The Greek word for know is *ginosko*. *Ginosko* does not refer to a learning of facts like one might memorize important dates in history or learn about key events in someone's life. *Ginosko* means to be connected intimately in experience, like two people come to know each other in marriage. *Ginosko* implies a deep, honest, relational knowing of the heart.

There is a chasm of difference between knowing about someone and actually knowing someone *in experience*.

A huge gap exists between *knowing about* God and actually *knowing* God. We can correctly define God as all-powerful, all-knowing, everywhere-present—even as loving. These facts are true, but knowing the facts is not the same as knowing Him. Our spiritual journeys can start as intellectual pursuits, but they won't find fulfillment there. Eternal life cannot be reduced to truths we learn in a Bible study or by reading Scripture.

All too often, honest, searching people give up on God because religion tells them *about* God, but discourages them from *knowing and experiencing* Him. Christianity wasn't meant to be a religion. It wasn't meant to be reduced to a set of theological truths. Christianity is knowing Jesus—God made a man you can relate to—in an ongoing, relational way, as you know a spouse or a best friend.

But, how do you come to know God?

Relationships don't happen all at once. They begin gradually and grow over time.

The Holy Spirit helps make the truth of the Father and the Son a living reality in our lives. He uses our life experiences, character flaws and sins to help us see that God accepts us unconditionally. He reveals God to us through Scripture, answered prayer, dreams, the actions of others ... the simple beauty of a flower, a forest or a sunset. The Holy Spirit is wonderfully creative in the ways He opens our eyes and encourages us to trust in Jesus.

Our only part is to come to Jesus. Nothing else is required. He accepts us as the fearful, skeptical, sinful, needy people, we really are. Jesus said, “The one who comes to Me I will by no means cast out” (John 6:37).

God created each one of us for eternal life; we are meant to know Him. Without Him we are incomplete. Deep in the soul of every man, woman and child is the need to be appreciated, valued, and loved. This is the need God wants to satisfy. With heartfelt longing the Trinity desire you.

However, God gives us free choice. He won't force us into a relationship with Him—into eternal life. He won't force us ... because love, by its very nature, can't be forced. Love can only be given and received by choice. Think of a young man who loves a certain woman. He wants to be with her. He lavishes her with gifts that he wants her to enjoy. He delights in her and he wants her to feel the same about him. But the young woman doesn't have to accept his love. Mutual loving relationship is only possible where there is freedom to choose. Our participation is voluntary, not mandatory.

The passion of the Trinity for us is more than we can fathom. Jesus made the greatest sacrifice for you. Nothing brings heaven greater joy than that you choose Him.

Ponder for a Moment

If you desire to have a relationship with Jesus, sincerely say these words, or something similar, to Him.

Dear Jesus, You are the Son of God. You died on the cross for my sins. You love me just as I am right now.

Jesus, I welcome You. Be with me in the ups and downs of life. Teach me Your ways and be Lord of my life.

Thank You Jesus for coming to live in my heart and welcoming me into eternal life with You. Open my eyes and help me to see You as You really are. I want to know You more.